When the Team Goes Quiet



YOUR FIELD GUIDE

Make room for the conversation you're missing, and work out what you can change.

Nic Payne

For the conversations we need to make room for

OPEN YOUR LAB >

The meeting was quiet. The conversation afterward wasn't.

You asked if there were any concerns. Nobody said much. Later, someone tells you what they were worried about. You're glad to know. You also wish you'd heard it earlier.

Start with one moment

Choose a meeting you were part of. What happened just before the room went quiet? You don't need to explain the whole team's culture to begin.

Give yourself five minutes

Write down what you noticed, what you want to ask, and how you'll invite the conversation. That is enough to get started. The later pages help with the answer and what you do next.

Use the bits you need

Prepare in the Lab or on paper. Read the worked conversation if you want to see it unfold. The Scrum section is optional. You won't need this much preparation for every conversation; these habits get more familiar with practice.

What this helps you do

You'll have words to open the conversation, questions to help you understand, and a small change you can follow through on. The other person still gets to choose what they share.

You don't have to make the whole team open up today. Start by making one conversation worth having.

What did you actually notice?

Silence can mean a lot of things. Someone may agree, be thinking, lack the information, or be tired of having the same concern brushed aside. We need to ask.

Describe what happened

“I asked for concerns and moved on after a few seconds” is something you can check. “Nobody cares” is a conclusion. Keep those separate.

Look at your part

Did you interrupt, answer your own question, or explain why the plan couldn’t change before anyone spoke? Notice what you can own without making the conversation about your guilt.

Ask yourself who was missing

Did the people affected have a chance to see the plan? Was there time to think? If Support wasn’t invited, a quiet meeting tells you very little about what Support needs.

Keep private comments private

Prepare with neutral descriptions. Don’t collect a list of who said what about whom. Before repeating something shared privately, ask what the person is comfortable passing on.

Try writing two sentences: “What I noticed was…” and “What I still need to ask is…”

Prepare without writing a whole script.

If you only have five minutes, use these three prompts. You can think them through without writing anything down.

The moment

What did you notice, in words someone else in the meeting could recognise?

Your part

What did you say or do that you want to ask about or change?

Your invitation

Who do you want to understand, and what is one question you could ask them?

Stop when you have enough to begin. You can return to the rest after you've talked.

Give them a way into it.

Speak to the person whose experience you want to understand. If you interrupted them, start there. A short private conversation may be easier than asking them to explain themselves in front of everyone.

Name your part plainly

“I moved on while you were raising a question. I’m sorry. I’d like to hear what I missed.” You can explain the time pressure later if it helps; first, let them answer.

Ask about their experience

“What was it like trying to raise that?” is different from “Why didn’t you speak up?” Ask one question, then leave room for the answer.

Let them choose the setting

“Would you rather talk now, find another time, or send me a note?” They can decline. Don’t turn an invitation into another demand.

If you don’t run the meeting

Ask the person who does: “Could we leave a few minutes for questions before we decide?” You can make that request without speaking for colleagues or naming a private source.

An opening you can adapt: “I think I moved us on too quickly. What didn’t we get to hear?”

Before you explain, check you understood.

An uncomfortable answer can make you want to defend what you meant. Take a breath. First find out what happened for the other person.

Ask for an example

“Can you walk me through that moment?” Listen for what they were trying to contribute and what happened next. You’re learning about their experience, not testing whether they deserve to be upset.

Say it back in your own words

“Let me just synthesize this back to you to make sure I understand.” Then give a short account of what you heard. Or use: “Let me check I’ve got this.”

Leave room for a correction

“You wanted us to check the report before we agreed to Friday, and my answer made it sound like that wasn’t up for discussion. Is that right?” If they correct you, use the correction.

You can understand and still disagree

“I see why that worried you. I’m not sure we need to move the date, but we do need to check the report.” Hearing a concern doesn’t commit you to every solution suggested.

Ask “What have I missed?” before “Can I explain why I did that?”

Practise the moment you want to defend yourself.

Imagine hearing: “There isn’t much point raising concerns. You’ve already decided.” What happens inside you?

Pause

You don’t have to agree with the whole statement to ask what led to it.

Ask

“Can you give me an example? I want to understand what I did.”

Check

“When I presented the plan as settled, you thought the questions wouldn’t change anything. Have I got that?”

Then respond

If you did shut the conversation down, own it. If there is a misunderstanding, explain it after checking what you heard.

You’re practising a response, not memorising a performance.

What will you do differently?

A good conversation matters. What happens in the next meeting will give people something more to go on.

Choose something you control

You might send the plan earlier, stop interrupting, or ask what could go wrong before presenting your own view. Pick something you can actually do.

Ask whether it would help

“If I sent the plan the day before and left time for questions, would that help? What would still get in the way?” Their answer may change your idea.

Handle the work problem too

If the report is wrong, get the right people together to fix it. Don’t turn an urgent concern into a discussion about communication and leave the original problem untouched.

Make a promise you can keep

Name your action and when you’ll do it. If something needs another person’s approval, say that. Don’t promise that speaking up will never have consequences you can’t control.

> “At the next meeting, I’ll…” is a useful start. “We all need to be more open” leaves everyone guessing.

Why we do Scrum this way

If your team uses Scrum, these conversations already have a place. The November 2020 Scrum Guide describes opportunities to learn from the work and adjust it. These short summaries explain their purpose; the questions are suggestions for your team.

Sprint Planning

The whole Scrum Team plans together. Developers select the work with the Product Owner and decide how to do it. Ask: “What do we need to understand before we commit to this?”

Daily Scrum

Developers spend 15 minutes checking progress toward the Sprint Goal and adjusting their plan. Ask: “What needs to change today?” A report to the manager misses that purpose.

Sprint Review

The Scrum Team and stakeholders examine results and decide what to adapt. Ask: “What have we learned that should change what happens next?” Leave room for discussion, beyond a demonstration.

Sprint Retrospective

The Scrum Team plans improvements to quality and effectiveness. Ask: “Which change will we actually make?” Then check what happened.

Source: Ken Schwaber and Jeff Sutherland, The Scrum Guide (November 2020). Read the full definitions at scrumguides.org/scrum-guide.html.

You may not get the conversation you hoped for.

An invitation doesn't undo what came before it. How you respond now still matters.

"It's fine."

"Okay. You don't need to talk about it now. I'm still going to work on not cutting questions short." Leave the door open without repeatedly asking for a different answer.

"We've raised this before."

"You're right. What did we say we'd do, and what actually happened?" Start with the unfinished promise. Another discussion won't substitute for keeping it.

"I don't want you telling everyone I said this."

Ask what, if anything, they are comfortable sharing. You can change your own behaviour without identifying them. Don't promise secrecy if your role requires you to act on what you hear.

"There's a reason people don't speak up."

Take concrete accounts of threats, harassment, or retaliation seriously. A team conversation isn't a substitute for an appropriate reporting or support route. Ask what support is needed; don't press for a public account.

You can respect someone's choice not to talk and still change something you've noticed yourself.

Agile should leave room to learn.

Agile is a set of values and principles; Scrum is a framework a team may use. Neither requires you to pretend the plan is right when you've learned something that changes it.

Work with people

The Agile Manifesto gives more weight to people working together than to processes and tools. A board or a meeting format can help; it can't hear a concern for you.

Respond to what you learn

A plan is useful. The Manifesto also values responding to change. Explain what you learned and discuss what that means for the work.

Make improvement part of the work

The Agile principles call for regular reflection followed by changes in how the team works. A concern raised in a retrospective needs a response, not just a sticky note.

Keep a pace people can sustain

Sustainable work is an Agile principle too. If every honest answer about workload becomes a request for overtime, notice what that teaches people.

Sources: the Agile Manifesto and its twelve principles. The meeting questions in this tool are suggestions, not additional Scrum rules.

Come back with what you did.

After the next meeting or two, ask what was different. The point is to find out whether the change helped, not to get reassurance that you're a good leader.

Make your part visible

"I sent the plan earlier and left the release questions open until we'd heard from the people doing the work." Describe what you changed without announcing who prompted it.

Ask about a real moment

"Did you have enough information and time to raise a concern? What happened when you did?" More talking on its own doesn't prove people are being heard.

Notice what changed in the work

Did a question help you catch a problem or improve the plan? Did someone get an answer to a concern that used to go nowhere? Look for those moments.

Keep adjusting

If the same problem returns, ask what is still getting in the way. You may need help from the meeting owner or a more senior colleague. Say what you can do and what you need from them.

Follow-through sounds like: "We said we'd try this. Here's what happened. What should we keep or change?"

Make the next meeting easier to join.

Choose a change with the people who use the meeting. These are options to discuss, not a new set of ceremonies.

Before

Share the question or proposed plan early enough for people to look at it. Ask whose input is missing.

During

Give people a little time to think. Ask what you might be overlooking before announcing your preferred answer. Let people pass.

After

Say what changed because of the discussion, or explain why it didn't. Follow up on questions that still need an answer.

If you use Scrum

Involve your Scrum Master when the events aren't helping the team. The Guide describes self-management and the values of commitment, focus, openness, respect, and courage. These aren't a demand for personal disclosure.

A useful check: could someone name one time their input changed what happened?

Keep the follow-up short.

This fictional note contains the PM's proposed change. It leaves out the analyst's private comments. The PM has not yet discussed the change with the team.

What I'm changing

"For the next two planning meetings, I'll send the proposed plan the day before and leave time to hear concerns before we decide."

How you can take part

"You can bring a question to the meeting or send it beforehand. If I move on before you've finished, please tell me; I'll also work on noticing it myself."

When we'll check

"After the second meeting, let's check whether this gave us enough time to discuss what mattered."

Before you share it

Check the wording with anyone whose contribution you mention. Remove personal comments that aren't needed. Only call something agreed after the people involved have agreed to it.

A short note can be enough. You don't need to distribute your whole conversation plan.

What are people learning from working with us?

Holistic Shaping asks us to notice how work changes people, including us. A meeting is one of the everyday places where that happens.

Culture

What becomes normal here? If concerns are repeatedly waved away, people may learn that raising them isn't worth it. What happens next time can start to change that expectation.

Relationship

Can we question each other and stay curious? A colleague's concern may help us see something we missed. We have to leave room for it to change our thinking.

Identity

What place does a person come to believe they have here? Being heard as someone with judgment is different from being called on only to confirm the plan.

Vision

What are we trying to make possible together? Bring the conversation back to the people the work should help. That gives disagreement a purpose beyond proving who is right.

You're part of this too. What did the conversation change in how you see the work, the other person, or yourself?

The question that got cut short

The team is planning Friday's release of online booking. The report Support uses may not include bookings from the new page.

Data analyst

"There's something about the booking numbers we need to check."

PM

"Can we stick to the release plan? We're running out of time."

Data analyst, afterward

"I was trying to tell you the report might miss the new bookings."

Ask yourself: What do we know happened? What are we still guessing about why the analyst didn't continue?

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An invitation to talk

The PM asks for a short conversation away from the group.

PM

“I cut you off earlier. I’m sorry. Could we talk about what I missed? Now or later is fine.”

Data analyst

“I wasn’t trying to slow everything down. Support uses those numbers to plan tomorrow’s work.”

PM

“Tell me more. What do we need to check?”

Ask yourself: Does the opening give the analyst room to explain, or ask them to reassure the PM?

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Checking what was heard

The PM listens to the work concern and asks about the meeting.

PM

“Let me check I’ve got this. You wanted us to check the report before we agreed to Friday. When I moved on, it sounded like the decision was already made.”

Data analyst

“Yes. I wasn’t asking us to cancel. I needed someone to hear that there was a check missing.”

PM

“That makes sense. I should have let you finish. Can we get the report owner involved today?”

Ask yourself: What did the correction change in the PM’s understanding?

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A change they can try

The PM asks about the next meeting and what can be shared.

PM

“I’ll send the plan earlier and leave time for concerns before we decide. Would that help?”

Data analyst

“Yes. And if there’s a question you can’t answer, could we agree who will check it?”

PM

“Yes. Is it okay to tell the team we’re checking the report with its owner? I won’t repeat this conversation.”

Data analyst

“That’s fine. Let’s keep the rest between us.”

Ask yourself: Which part is the PM’s own promise, and which part did they check with the analyst?

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Two meetings later

They return to what they said they would try. It's a small start, with more to learn.

PM

"Did getting the plan earlier help?"

Data analyst

"Yes. I could check the numbers first. The question got a proper answer this time. We still rushed the last item."

PM

"I noticed that too. Let's put that question earlier next time and see how it goes."

Ask yourself: What actually improved, and what still needs attention?

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A little more help.

Stop Chasing Psychological Safety

Nic Payne · Article

Nic explores how people can misread one another's contributions. Read it when a practical concern sounds to you like someone blocking the idea.

What was the other person trying to help us see?

Take this into your Lab >

ChapGPT schools me on leading well

Nic Payne · Article

A reflection from Nic on how we meet another person. Read or watch before a conversation you've already decided the meaning of.

Can their answer change my view?

Take this into your Lab >

You Have a Culture Problem

Nic Payne · Article

Nic's Cultural Orbital Mechanics connects culture, identity, relationship, and vision. Read it alongside the question of what repeated meetings teach people.

What are we making normal each time we meet?

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A little more help.

When Mattering Isn't Enough

Nic Payne · Article

Nic asks what comes after feeling valued. Read it when you want the conversation to change more than how the meeting feels.

What room have we made for someone's judgment to change the work?

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The Hollow Crown: Why Our Leadership Narratives Have Failed

Nic Payne · Article

Nic questions the expectation that a better individual leader can solve everything. Read it when the same problem keeps returning despite your efforts.

What needs to change beyond my own behaviour?

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The Scrum Guide (November 2020)

Ken Schwaber and Jeff Sutherland · Guide

The original definitions, accountabilities, events, and values. Use it to check what a meeting is for before changing how you run it.

What should this event help us learn or change?

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A little more help.

Principles behind the Agile Manifesto

The Agile Manifesto authors · Principles

The original twelve principles, including regular reflection and sustainable work. Read them with your team and choose one to discuss.

Which principle is hardest to recognise in our week?

Take this into your Lab >

Manifesto for Agile Software Development

The Agile Manifesto authors · Manifesto

Read the four values in full. They explain a preference, not permission to discard tools, documentation, agreements, or plans.

Where does our routine help those values, and where does it get in the way?

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